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Lawmakers, Advocates Introduce Legislation to Protect Californians From Hazardous 'Forever Chemicals' in Drinking Water

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WASHINGTON, Feb. 20 -- The Environmental Working Group issued the following news release on Feb. 19, 2025:

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Lawmakers, advocates introduce legislation to protect Californians from hazardous 'forever chemicals' in drinking water

* A.B. 794 would establish new state drinking water standards to protect Californians from PFAS contamination.

* PFAS exposure has been linked to serious health harms, including cancer and developmental issues in children.

SACRAMENTO, Calif. - Today Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) introduced Assembly Bill 794, which would mandate new state drinking water standards to protect Californians from exposure to the toxic and dangerous "forever chemicals" known as PFAS.

Exposure to PFAS has been linked to serious health harms, including cancer, cardiovascular diseases, reproductive harm and developmental issues in infants and children.

Recent tests suggest that nearly 12 million Californians are exposed to tap water with PFAS contamination.

Last year, following an extensive review of scientific research, as well as over 120,000 public comments, the Biden administration's Environmental Protection Agency established the first-ever national drinking water standards to protect Americans from PFAS exposure. However, recent efforts by corporate polluters to challenge federal standards have raised concerns that the new federal administration could weaken or roll back these protections.

A.B. 794 would address these concerns by requiring the California State Water Board to adopt and enforce state-level regulations to protect Californians from PFAS exposure. The legislation would direct the state water board to establish emergency regulations that are at least as protective as current federal standards, while also allowing the state to conduct its own analysis and adopt even stronger protections if warranted.

"Californians shouldn't have to worry that their drinking water has been contaminated by toxic 'forever chemicals' linked to deadly cancers and other serious health harms," said Gabriel. "Today we are taking action to ensure that California is leading with strong, science-based health standards that will protect our communities from harmful PFAS chemicals, regardless of what happens at the federal level.

"This bill will ensure that we follow the best available science to safeguard the health and safety of our children while also preserving our ability to strengthen protections in the future," he added.

A.B. 794 is supported by a coalition of public health and environmental groups that includes the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists, California Environmental Voters, the Sierra Club, Clean Water Action and the Environmental Working Group.

Background on PFAS

PFAS make up a category of chemicals used since the 1940s that are found in everyday products like nonstick

cookware, stain-resistant fabrics and firefighting foam. Scientific research has clearly demonstrated that sustained exposure to PFAS can cause cancer and other illnesses, and that PFAS exposure is especially dangerous during pregnancy and early childhood.

Last year, the Biden administration adopted the first national drinking water standards to protect Americans from PFAS exposure. In so doing, it cited activated carbon, reverse osmosis, and ion exchange systems as examples of available technologies and approaches that can help to protect against PFAS exposure. The EPA likewise noted that the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law includes $21 billion to help upgrade drinking water systems to incorporate such technologies.

California currently lags behind at least 11 other states in regulating PFAS, leaving millions of residents at risk of exposure to these dangerous forever chemicals. By setting enforceable state limits on PFAS, A.B. 794 would help to prevent thousands of deaths and serious illnesses, as well as future medical expenses and environmental cleanup costs.

What environmental leaders are saying about A.B. 794

Scott Faber, senior vice president for government affairs, Environmental Working Group

If PFAS polluters successfully persuade the Trump EPA to weaken or eliminate federal PFAS drinking water protections, millions of Californians will have no protections from PFAS in their tap water. California must take bold action now to set its own drinking water limits to make sure protections from these toxic forever chemicals don't depend on the Trump EPA.

Melissa Romero, policy advocacy director, California Environmental Voters

PFAS contamination is a public health crisis that puts children and families at risk, with devastating health consequences and staggering cleanup costs. These toxic chemicals have been linked to serious illnesses, including cancer and developmental issues, yet the burden of exposure and medical expenses falls hardest on everyday people - especially those in vulnerable communities.

No parent should have to worry about whether the water their child drinks is safe. By passing this bill, we're taking a critical step toward protecting public health and preventing future generations from bearing the cost of inaction.

Dr. Juliana Melo, M.S.C.S., University of California Davis Health

The American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists has long been committed to reducing exposure to toxic chemicals in order to ensure a healthier future for our patients. Keeping PFAS out of our drinking water is an important step in this direction. The science is clear and so is our responsibility - to ensure that every woman can go through pregnancy without the added burden of toxic chemical exposure, and that every baby has the best possible start in life.

Andria Ventura, legislative and policy director, Clean Water Action

California law states that safe drinking water is a human right. Given the Trump administration's record of putting corporate polluter interests above public health, A.B. 794 is essential to safeguard the tens of millions of Californians affected by PFAS in their water sources.

Clean Water Action thanks Assemblymember Gabriel for his leadership, and we're proud to work toward the bill's passage.

Gabriela Facio, policy strategist, California Sierra Club

Potential federal rollbacks could expose millions of Californians to heightened risk of toxic PFAS contamination. This

bill is a critical step toward ensuring that our state takes decisive action to protect communities from PFAS pollution, regardless of federal policy changes.

We must ensure every Californian's right to access safe, clean water. The cost of inaction is too high for Californian's public health and the environment.

Jesse Gabriel proudly represents the San Fernando Valley in the California Legislature.

The Environmental Working Group is a nonprofit, non-partisan organization that empowers people to live healthier lives in a healthier environment. Through research, advocacy and unique education tools, EWG drives consumer choice and civic action.

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Original text here: https://www.ewg.org/news-insights/news-release/2025/02/lawmakers-advocates-introduce-legislation-protect-californians

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